

Outbreak of WWII in Europe

Worldwide GD

World trade boomed in late 1920s

- Economic prosperity ⇒ eased international tensions
 - Example: US provided loans to German banks ⇒ help stabilize economy after 1924
 - Led to French troops leaving Ruhr Region

Period of economic prosperity ⇒ end in October 1929 ⇒ US stock market crashed.

Effect of GD → Economic Nationalism

Responses to GD

1. Protectionism Some countries (Br, Fr, US) → introduced tariffs → to protect their own industries + limit or stop imports Their trading partners did the same → resulting in overall fall in trade volumes.	2. Calling in Loans As the US economy struggled => US banks called in their loans. Led to collapse of Banks and businesses which in turn caused mass unemployment
3. Rearmament Many countries (Britain, France, Italy and Japan) began the rearmament process to boost industry and create jobs for the unemployed	4. Radicalism In some countries => Great Depression helped bring radical regimes to power => most notably the Nazi party in Germany. in other states such as Italy => the GD caused existing regimes to adopt more extreme and aggressive policies.

Emergence of Authoritarian Regimes

Period of 1930s:

- Rise of Nazism in Germany
- Rise of Fascism in Italy

Germany	Italy
• economic and political challenges after WWI • GD ⇒ destabilized economy even further ⇒ Bringing Nazi party into power • Beyond economic recovery > Nazi party wanted to reclaim land lost under TOV + carve out living space for Germans in eastern Europe + destroy communism in Germany and wherever it could be found	Led by Benito Mussolini • used GD as opportunity to tighten grip on Country by taking control of banks and industries. • long held ambitions ⇒ to build Italian empire around eastern Mediterranean and North Africa. • He felt Italy had much more in common to Germany⇒ started to discuss alliance ⇒ formalized in 1939

Desire of Italy and Germany to redraw their borders ⇒ meant European peace and stability was increasingly fragile by final years of 1930s.

Failures of LON in 1930s

by 1930s ⇒ Leagues reputation had declined

when Japan invaded Manchuria in 1931 ⇒ League reacted slowly and ineffectively.

1935 ⇒ many states had begun losing faith in the league.

Failure of Disarmament

1 of key aims of league ⇒ encourage disarmament among countries

League + prominent state actors ⇒ led international talks to promote disarmament ⇒ as early as 1920s

Washington Naval Conference – 1921 (SUCCESS) • Negotiated outside league to limit size + number of warships held by Br, Fr, Japan, US • Organised by US → not league member • ratio of tonnage of capital ships of Britian, US, Japan, Fr, Italy → 5:5:3:1.67:1.67	Locarno Treaties – 1925 (PARTIAL SUCCESS) • negotiated outside league between Br, G, Fr, Italy Belgium, Poland, Czechoslovakia. • Germany accepted its western borders → including demilitarization of Rhineland • WG → agreed to settle any disputes with above mentioned countries through league.
League Commission to Prepare for World Disarmament Conference – 1926 (FAILURE) • Failed → Britain + France refused to cooperate	Kellogg – Briand Pact – 1928 (FAILURE) • Negotiated outside league → between 15 countries → including US, Fr, G, Br, Italy, Japan • Agreement that force should not be used to settle disputes • No clear way to enforce pact

Overall progress on disarmament → still limited.

- 1930s → increasing tensions in world → began to make world leaders more inclined towards wanting an arms force
 - WORLD DISARMAMENT CONFERENCE, 1932-1934

Abyssinian Crisis

- Fatal blow to the league ⇒ when Italian dictator ⇒ Benito Mussolini ⇒ invaded Abyssinia (Ethiopia) in 1935
 - Italy had been under control of fascists led by Mussolini since 1933
 - ⇒ he had long held ambitions to build Italian empire + bring back glory days or Roman empire
- ⇒ View that established powers such as Britain and France were in decline → strengthened when Nazis took power in Germany in 1933
- ⇒ Mussolini ⇒ Italy had much more to gain from friendship with Germany ⇒ began to discuss alliance
- ⇒ ⇒ with this alliance → Mussolini became more aggressive with Italy's foreign policy

Origins of Abyssinian Crisis

Italian troops ⇒ tried to invade Abyssinia ⇒ Defeated by poorly equipped army of tribesmen

- Mussolini wanted revenge for humiliating defeat
- Also wanted fertile lands and mineral wealth of Abyssinia
- wanted glory and conquest

There was dispute between Abyssinian and Italian soldiers at the Wal Wal oasis in Abyssinia

- used this as an excuse to claim oasis as Italian territory
- demanded apology from Abyssinia
- began to prepare Italian army to invade it

Abyssinian Emperor ⇒ asked league for help ⇒ unsuccessful

Britain ⇒ had influence and resources to act decisively on Abyssinia's behalf

location of Britain and France's colonies ⇒ meant they could send troops to Defend Abyssinia

- chose not to do so

1. Mussolini ⇒ agreed to negotiate with League over Abyssinia → same time he began moving armed forces into Italian Bases in Eritrea (Africa) ⇒ next to Abyssinia.	2. Tensions between Italy and Abyssinia were escalating → Britain, France and US ⇒ signed agreement ⇒ Stresa Front → coalition formed to oppose Hitler's announced intention to rearm Germany ⇒ which was against terms of TOV
3. Public outcry in Britain against Mussolini under pressure ⇒ British Foreign secretary ⇒ Samuel Hoare ⇒ made speech to league ⇒ supporting collective security + rights of small nations	4. Britain and France ⇒ anxious to not upset Mussolini ⇒ as he was a potential ally against Hitler's Germany. → result ⇒ there was no action taken by the 2 powers or the LON ⇒ against Mussolini ⇒ league put forward plan: - Give Mussolini a few parts of Abyssinia - he rejected it
5. Did not want to drive Italy into arms of Germany → foreign ministers of Britain and France (Samuel Hoare and Pierre Laval) ⇒ secretly discussed Hoare-Laval Pact with Mussolini → wanted to give 2/3 of Abyssinia to Mussolini ⇒ and he would call off invasion → plan was made while league was discussing sanctions against Italy → when details of plan was leaked to French press: - people of Britain and France viewed it as treachery against league → both Hoare and Laval sacked ⇒ plan was dropped.	6. October 1934 ⇒ Mussolini army → ready → launched a full-scale invasion → of Abyssinia. ⇒ Abyssinian soldiers were brave → no match for modern Italian army ⇒ equipped with tanks, airplanes and poison gas

7. League immediately set up a committee to discuss what sanctions to impose against Mussolini Sanctions would only work ⇒ if they were imposed quickly + decisively. each delay ⇒ would allow Mussolini ⇒ to build up his stockpile of raw materials.	8. League ⇒ banned arms sales + all loans → also banned exports of rubber tin and metals ⇒ banned all imports from Italy
9. League ⇒ concluded that stopping of sales to Italy would exhaust its supply in 2months However ⇒ leagues delay in committing to decision ⇒ meant it was already too late. ⇒ US refused to support ban of oil sales. → instead increased its supplies of oils to Italy	10. Suez Canal ⇒ owned by Britain and France ⇒ remained open to Italy's supply ships
11. Both Britain and France ⇒ afraid ⇒ closing the canal would cause war with Italy. ⇒ failure was fatal for Abyssinia 6 countries officially protested against Mussolini's actions → May 1936 ⇒ Italy conquered Abyssinia ⇒ Abyssinian Emperor ⇒ Haile Selassie ⇒ went into exile	

League Loses Credibility

Abyssinian crisis → damaged global confidence in the league.

Leak of Hoare Laval Pact details → damaged reputation

Failure to impose sanctions on Italy decisively → led to Italian takeover of Abyssinia

- result Hitler was convinced → league would not be able to hinder Germany's plan of expansion

Midst of Abyssinian crisis → German troops marched into Rhineland → March 1936

⇒ act against TOV → league did nothing to stop it

Nov 1936 → Italy and Germany → signed agreement → Rome Berlin Axis → league could do nothing about

Lack of authority in enforcing peacekeeping measures → resulted in collapse of collective security.

⇒ Eroded its credibility + showed ineffectiveness in resolving conflicts + maintaining world peace

World Disarmament Conference, 1932-1934

Concerned with increasing tensions in world → league managed to persuade US + 60 other states → to attend world disarmament conference.

→ Held at Leagues headquarters in Geneva → Feb 1932

Limiting Offensive Weapons

- Tried to control destructive power of offensive weapons
- Produced resolutions to ban bombing of civilian populations + chemical warfare + limit size of artillery + tonnage of tanks

Leaders couldn't agree on a few matters

- Difficult to get countries to agree on what offensive and defensive weapons were
- ⇒ Resolutions passed → not effective in ensuring how limitations on weapons would be achieved.
- Bombing of civilians was to be banned → all attempts to agree to ban planes capable of bombing were unsuccessful.
 - Proposal to ban chemical weapons also unsuccessful

Individual countries used conference to raise own problems. Selfish

- Italy wanted same navy size as France

Dealing with Germany

What to do with Germany was the biggest issue.

- Most countries shared views → that terms set out in TOV → should be fairer to Germany
 - Terms limiting size of Germany's army → perceived to be unfair
 - There was disagreement to how fair arrangement should be achieved.
- ⇒ Option 1: every country disarms to level that was like that Germany was forced to do so
- ⇒ Option 2: allow Germany to rearm to level closer to that of other powers
- ➔ Reluctance to allow either option

Experience of disarmament efforts in 1920s → proved most countries would not disarm.

France → wary of Germany → due to its painful experience in WW1 → pressured league against taking up option 2.

- Demanded:
 - Either France continues to have larger army size compared to Germany, Britain, US
 - Britain and US guarantee to fight alongside France if war between France and Germany broke out.

Disagreements continued

- US did not want to commit themselves to guaranteeing France's future security
- Same time → Germany accused France and other powers of Hypocrisy

July 1932 → Germany put forward proposal → for other powers to disarm down to Germany's extent

- ➔ Conference failed to agree on principle of equality → Germans walked out + conference broke up.

Conference Reconvenes

conference broke up ⇒ league officials continued to work behind scenes ⇒ with Germany and other powers

- December 1932 → other powers agreed to decide equality for Germany
- Germany thus returned to discussions → disarmament conference reconvened

Important changes:

- Germany → new leader → Hitler
 - Attended conference + appeared interested in making progress on disarmament
 - (reality he wasn't interested + secretly started rearmament program in Germany)

When military commanders → secretly making plans for rearmament → Hitler pretended to engage with other powers on issue of disarmament.

- Promised to not rearm Germany → if other powers agreed to disarm within 5 years
- Was trying to put pressure on other powers (Esp. France)

Hitler playing clever game

- Calling for large scale disarmament and knew other powers would not agree to disarm to same level as Germany faced under TOV
- Gave him justification to rearm Germany

Oct 1933 → Pulled Germany out of the disarmament conference and from LON

Nazi Germany's Aggressive Foreign Policy

Hitlers Aims and Beliefs

Nazi party believed in aggressive form of nationalism → putting Germany and its people before anyone or anything else

- Party offered radical solutions to Germany's economic problems

→ Includes the following:

- Massive rearmament programs
- State control of industry + state investment in projects such as roadbuilding
- Getting rid of TOV to end reparation payments + reclaim territories which were lost under the treaty

Germany's increasing aggression in 1933-1937

(Hitler lost no time in turning his words into actions. ⇒ from 1933 to 1937 ⇒ he began dismantling some of the main elements of the TOV and imposing his will on international relations)

1933	Leaving LON • In referendum organised by Nazi govt → German people voted in favour of withdrawing from LON ⇒ Hitler withdrew G from Lon in Oct → as Germany had been treated unequally → on Germany rearmament Undermined authority of the league
1933-1935	Rearmament • Nazi govt → began rearmament in 1933 → although this was banned in TOV • 1000s of unemployed workers → drafted into army to help reduce unemployment Germany → began to build up armed forces → initially in secret ⇒ 1935: Hitler no longer bothered to hide rearmament program ⇒ Hed freedom to rearm rally in Berlin ⇒ Popularity + prestige in Germany grew ⇒ Br, Fr, Poland, Czechoslovakia, USSR → concerns grew over Germany's build up

1934	Disarmament Conference ⇒ Hitler walked out of the LON's Disarmament conference ⇒ claiming that Germany was not being treated equally. → major blow → to chances of a disarmament agreement → conference ended soon after.
1935	Saar Plebiscite ⇒ Saar region had been run by LON since 1919 ⇒ Hitler claimed it should be a part of Germany ⇒ League forced Hitler to agree to a plebiscite (vote) → resulted in 90% of people in Saar voting to join Hitler's Germany ⇒ Further increased Hitler's power + confidence
1936	Remilitarization of Rhineland <u>TOV:</u> • Banned German forces → from entering Rhineland region → acted as border for France • Hitler declared this was unacceptable → because France + USSR → agreed on treaty of mutual assistance in Feb → promising to protect each other against G. • Hitler claimed he was being encircled → therefore had right to place troops on his own borders March → ordered German troops into Rhineland ⇒ Was a gamble → because German army was still not strong enough to stand up to French response ⇒ If French had called his bluff + moved troops in → he would have been humiliated + lost support of army (as German generals were unsure about Hitler) However, Britain, France, League → preoccupied with Abyssinian Crisis ⇒ Britain would not guarantee their support for France → If France challenged Hitler ⇒ League → condemned Hitler's actions → no further actions taken ⇒ Hitler gained more prestige + confidence in eyes of Germans.
1936	Spanish Civil War July → civil war broke out in Spain → between Republicans and Nationalists Nationalist leader → General Franco → held beliefs that were like Hitler and Mussolini's → so they helped him with troops, aircraft and other equipment ⇒ Also gave Hitler opp. To test his army and air force (Luftwaffe) Might of German air force → was demonstrated when German aircraft → bombed republican strongholds → caused casualties Br. + Fr. → stayed out of Spanish civil war ⇒ Encouraged Hitler as he now believed Br and F were not prepared to go to war at all. ⇒ Same time → USSR → increasingly suspicious of Br + Fr → because of reluctance to oppose Hitler and Mussolini

1936	Anti Communist party • While tensions rising in Europe → Japan expanding in Asia ⇒ G + Italy → saw they had much in common → with military dictatorship in Japan. 1936 → Germany + Japan → signed anti Comintern pact. ⇒ To oppose communist international (Comintern) ➔ Comintern was set up by USSR → wanted to spread communism by promoting uprisings around the world. ➔ Members of anti-Comintern pact → also agreed to not sign any treaties with USSR
1937	Axis Alliance Soon after in 1937 → Italy also signed anti Comintern pact. ⇒ New alliance between Germany, Italy, Japan → known as Axis alliance

Factors Affecting Britain and France's Decision Making in 1930s	
1. US Isolationism	After WW1: ⇒ US adopted policy of isolationism → in early 1920s and 1930s ⇒ Did not want to get involved in European affairs because loss of human lives it had suffered due to war ⇒ Thus, help from US against Hitler was not option
2. Sympathy for Germany	There was criticism of TOV in Europe • People around Europe → felt it was fair → for Hitler to argue that Germany → was being unfairly treated → if it had to disarm while other countries were unwilling to do so. ⇒ When Hitler reclaimed Saar and Rhineland → few spoke up against him ⇒ Politicians → aware of Sympathy that people had for Germany.
3. National Interest	Both Britain and France prioritised their own interests • For much of 1930s → Britain more worried about Stalin + USSR than they were about Hitler • Saw Germany as useful barrier against USSR. • E.g. in 1935 → signed Anglo German Naval Agreement with Germany → which allowed it to build a navy up to 35% size of British navy ⇒ Broke TOV • France → more worried about Hitler than Stalin → as France and Germany shared border • Since Britain would not formalise an alliance with France → French turned to USSR → 1936 → and signed treaty of Mutual Assistance • Alarmed British + created more sympathy for Germany → which helped Nazi party → occupy the Rhineland with little opposition.
4. Misjudgement of Hitler	British and French → Politicians → could neither comprehend → real threat → that Hitler and his ideology posed nor foresee the events that followed

Policy of Appeasement in 1930s

⇒ Britain and France → basically gave in to Hitler's demands.

1937 ⇒ Britain new PM ⇒ Nevil Chamberlain ⇒ continued to pursue policy of appeasement.

⇒ however he was aware of the potential threat posed by Hitler.

⇒ While Britain ⇒ adopted policy of appeasement ⇒ Chamberlain ⇒ also authorized ⇒ massive spending on rearmament for Britain ⇒ and recognized that Britain and France need to support each other.

Anschluss with Austria, 1938

1938 ⇒ Hitler next targeted Austria

⇒ he wanted to unite the Germans of Austria with Germany.

Austria ⇒ had been a great power before WW1 ⇒ and many Austrians ⇒ were keen to be a part of Hitler's new and successful Germany.

⇒ TOV → specifically forbade this but this did not deter Hitler

- Strong Nazi party in Austria ⇒ Hitler encouraged them to instigate union with Germany, or Anschluss
- Although ⇒ he created the disorder in the first place ⇒ he convinced Austrian Chancellor, Kurt Schuschnigg ⇒ that order could only be restored if German troops moved into Austria
- ⇒ appealed to Britain and France ⇒ to put pressure on Hitler to withdraw ⇒ but they did nothing

Hitler ⇒ marched troops into Austria in March 1938.

⇒ April 1938 → Hitler held a plebiscite ⇒ on Anschluss in Austria.

→ through voter intimidation and fraud ⇒ 99.75% of Austrian Voters approved of the Anschluss

Consequences of Anschluss for International Relations

- With Anschluss ⇒ Germany absorbed Austria's population, industry, and natural resources
- Germany ⇒ had access to Austria's reserves of gold.
 - → result → Germany's size and stature was strengthened
- Anschluss ⇒ saw Hitler's powers and standing increase.
- ⇒ he was breaking TOV ⇒ but Britain and France ⇒ did nothing
- Britain ⇒ sympathised ⇒ with Germany ⇒ for it felt that the TOV ⇒ was unfair and that Germans should be able to unite if they wanted to
- Britain's foreign secretary ⇒ Lord Halifax ⇒ told Hitler before the Anschluss ⇒ that Britain would not oppose him
- Britain and France ⇒ misjudged ⇒ Hitler's actions ⇒ and ambitions
 - → they found it hard to deal with a politician → who simply did not care about rules and traditions of international diplomacy.
- As a result, ⇒ they misunderstood and underestimated him.

Sudetenland and Munich Agreement, 1938

Czechoslovakia's leader ⇒ Edvard Benes ⇒ was horrified ⇒ by Anschluss

→ felt that his country would be the next target on Hitler's list

→ Benes ⇒ asked for and received ⇒ promises from Britain and France that they would protect him country against Hitler

Hitler ⇒ was indeed interested ⇒ in Czechoslovakia ⇒ because Sudetenland region of the country was largely populated by Germans.

- ⇒ there was a small but active Nazi Party in Sudetenland.
- ⇒ Like what he had done in Austria > Hitler encouraged Nazis ⇒ to stir up trouble in the Sudetenland + and demand to Join Germany
- ⇒ May 1938 ⇒ Hitler claimed to protect the Sudeten Germans ⇒ and threatened to invade if Czechoslovakia ⇒ did not hand over Sudetenland

Crisis Talks - Agreement at Munich, 1939

Benes ⇒ was prepared to fight ⇒ because he had a modern army and the support of Britain and France.

Neither Hitler nor Benes ⇒ backed down ⇒ and most people believed that the likelihood of war was high

British > prepared for the war by digging air raid shelters

Magazines ⇒ carried advertisements ⇒ for air raid protection and gas masks

Cards ⇒ carried instructions about how people could protect themselves from air raids.

By mid-September ⇒ situation had reached crisis point

Chamberlain ⇒ made one last effort to avoid war in Czechoslovakia

Sequence of events leading to the signing of the Munich Agreement

15-sep	Chamberlain → flew to meet Hitler in Bavaria Germany. ⇒ Hitler moderated his demands → stating he would claim part of Sudetenland → with majority of Germans. ⇒ Chamberlain ⇒ was convinced that Hitler would be satisfied with his demands.
19-sep	Britain + France → convinced Czechoslovakia to surrender parts of Sudetenland Hitler wanted
22-sep	Hitler ⇒ increased his demands + wanted whole of Sudetenland ⇒ he claimed that he needed to rescue ⇒ Sudeten Germans ⇒ who were being poorly treated by the Czechoslovak govt. ⇒ Chamberlain ⇒ told Hitler his demands ⇒ were unreasonable ⇒ and requested a conference with Hitler.
29-sep	Leaders of Britain, France, Italy and Germany ⇒ met in Munich for a 4-power summit. • they decided to give in to Hitler's demands ⇒ without consulting Czechoslovakia or USSR. • they agreed that the whole of Sudetenland → would be given to Germany ⇒ in exchange for a pledge of peace from Hitler → known as Munich agreement
30-sep	Next Morning ⇒ Chamberlain and Hitler ⇒ published a joint declaration ⇒ in which Chamberlain ⇒ claimed that the Agreement would bring "peace for our time"

Reactions to Munich agreement

- Immediately after signing of the Munich agreement → newspapers and newsreels ⇒ sold to people all over Europe that war had been prevented.
- Chamberlain ⇒ was greeted by cheering crowds.
- British media ⇒ also presented Munich Agreement ⇒ positively

Majority of the British people ⇒ did not think appeasement would stop Hitler.

Invasion of Czechoslovakia

October 1938 ⇒ Hitler moved his forces into the Sudetenland.

- ➔ claimed that this was the end of his demands.
- ➔ proved to be a lie.

March 15, 1939, ⇒ German troops took over the rest of Czechoslovakia

- For Chamberlain ⇒ It was a step too far.
- Unlike the Sudeten Germans ⇒ Czechs ⇒ were not separated from their homeland by the TOV.
- if Hitler ⇒ continued unchecked ⇒ his next target was likely to be Poland.
- Britain and France ⇒ threatened to declare war on Germany ⇒ if Hitler invaded Poland.

Nazi-Soviet Non-Aggression Pact, 1939

Hitler's Concerns

- Hitler ⇒ did have his eye on Poland.
- wanted to reclaim Polish corridor + city of Danzig
- was confident that the Polish forces → could be defeated

Despite their threat to go to war ⇒ Hitler thought that it was unlikely for Britain and France ⇒ to risk war over Poland

However, ⇒ he was worried ⇒ that Stalin would oppose Germany's invasion of Poland ⇒ since Poland bordered the USSR.

if USSR ⇒ opposed Germany's invasion ⇒ there was a possibility ⇒ that Britain and France would act.

- Germany would thus risk facing a 2-front war → where it would have to fight Britain and France on the western front and the USSR on the eastern front.
- would be disadvantageous for Germany

Stalin's Concerns

- 1934 ⇒ Stalin joined LON ⇒ and in 1936 ⇒ he signed the Mutual Assistance Pact with France

However, ⇒ he saw Britain, France and the League had not resisted Hitler ⇒ when he rearmed Germany ⇒ and took over territories in Europe.

- This ⇒ increased his concerns ⇒ about the Munich Agreement .

⇒ he was not consulted about it → it seemed that Britain and France → were allowing Hitler to take over Eastern Europe.

Signing of Nazi Soviet Non-Aggression Pact

- Negotiations between Stalin, Chamberlain, and France's Prime Minister, Edouard Daladier ⇒ continued through the first half of 1939
 - their intent was to form an alliance → against Hitler.
- Stalin was also meeting Germany's foreign minister ⇒ about a very different alliance.
- 23 August 1939 ⇒ 2 opposing forces ⇒ USSR and Germany ⇒ signed the Nazi Soviet pact.

Nazi Soviet Pact

- both countries agreed not to attack each other.
- Privately → they also agreed to divide Poland ⇒ between them.
- Germany ⇒ agreed to let USSR take eastern Poland and Baltic states of Lithuania, Latvia and Estonia.
- ➔ in reality: neither Hitler nor Stalin ⇒ had any faith in the agreement.

Stalin ⇒ had decided ⇒ that British and French ⇒ were probably too weak ⇒ to stand up against Hitler.

→ was playing for time to get these forces ready in the event → that Hitler turned against the Pact.
⇒ on the other hand: Hitler got the guarantee → he needed to invade Poland.

Invasion of Poland

- Germany's interest ⇒ in Polish corridor and Danzig ⇒ was due to large population of Germans and desire for a transportation line across Polish corridor ⇒ that separated Germany from the province of East Prussia.
 - Since April 1939 ⇒ Germany ⇒ had taken action to demand Polish corridor and Danzig.
 - However, ⇒ Polish leaders ⇒ rejected these demands.
 - They did not trust Hitler ⇒ and were concerned about a German invasion
 - Tensions → between Poland and Germany → escalated → as talks and negotiations between them broke down.
 - 1 September 1939 ⇒ certain that there would be no opposition from the USSR ⇒ because of the Pact ⇒ Germany invaded Poland.
 - However, ⇒ Hitler miscalculated that Britain and France would not go to war over Poland.
 - 3 September 1939 ⇒ Britain and France ⇒ declared war on Germany.
 - ➔ World war II had begun
-